

A VILLAGE OF WOES

The site for the Games Village on the riverbed of the Yamuna is in the eye of the storm as green crusaders take up cudgels against the lavish permanent structures being built to house athletes and delegates



■ By Newly Paul



The 2010 Commonwealth Games are being touted as Delhi's ticket to the list of world-class, ultramodern metropolises. The grand plans that leave no stone unturned—literally—centre on infrastructure development, and this is precisely what has the green brigade up in arms. The site for the Games Village on the riverbed of the Yamuna is in the eye of the storm. Environmentalists are seeing red over what will serve as a luxury block of 1,168 condominiums to accommodate over 8,000 athletes and delegates. Once the Games are over, the flats, fitted with Italian marble floors, sauna, jacuzzi and other modern fixtures, will be sold. As part of the deal, Emaar MGF, which won the contract for Rs 321 crore, will hand over one-third of the flats to the Delhi Development Authority (DDA).

Even as the decision on a PIL filed by environmental groups in the Delhi High Court is expected this month, more than 20 per cent of the construction has already been completed. Environmentalists believe that construction on the ecologically sensitive floodplains that prevent water from flooding outside the riverbed will wreak havoc on the city. Any permanent structure over the area might lead to the flooding of the entire east Delhi region, which lies 3-5m below the high flood level and is populated by 28-30 lakh people.

While experts say that flood water mixed with sewage could even enter west Delhi through reverse flow into the 18 drains which empty into the river, DDA's project incharge for the Games, Shekhar Dey, argues that the construction level is higher than the flood level. "The Village does not fall in the floodplain and the earthquake-resistant structures are being built in collaboration with the The Energy and

SEEING RED: Environmentalists say construction on the floodplain will wreak havoc on the city

UNCOMMON CONTROVERSY

Environmentalists say the floodplains should not be built upon as they lie in a high seismic zone.

Builders say the Village does not fall in the floodplain and the construction level is higher than the flood level.

The floodplain is a crucial water recharge zone and permanent constructions may damage this essential source of water.

Those in favour of the construction say the area is perfect for the Village as it is centrally located.

It is argued that temporary structures are impractical.